as opaque and out-of-touch institutions, fueling populist criticism. Efforts to sideline constituents through covert engagement may also exacerbate concerns about IO interference in domestic politics, further entrenching populist narratives about sovereignty violations.

In this chapter, we demonstrate that IOs use secrecy to combat populist resistance. This idea fits with a large literature that finds states often use secrecy to enact policies that domestic audiences find troublesome (Schuessler 2010). IOs help states funnel controversial foreign aid (Dreher et al. 2018) and make secret deals (Dreher and Jensen 2007; Dreher 2009; Vreeland and Dreher 2014). Secrecy also allows IOs to link disparate issues without mobilizing domestic resistance (Davis 2004) and can allow leaders to compromise more easily (Stasavage 2004; Hafner-Burton, Steinert-Threlkeld, and Victor 2016).

Secrecy can, however, also raise concerns about a lack of transparency in IOs, especially given that they often demand transparency from member states. Balancing covert engagement with efforts to address populist grievances transparently is essential to maintaining the legitimacy and effectiveness of IOs. By pairing secrecy with other strategies like appeasement, IOs can better navigate the challenges posed by populism while reinforcing their foundational principles, as we discuss further in the concluding chapter.

6.2 Forms of Covert Engagement

To maintain relationships with populist leaders while mitigating public backlash, IOs often employ covert engagement strategies. These strategies range from partial to full secrecy and can leverage both existing and novel channels for discreet interaction.

Partial secrecy involves obscuring certain aspects of state–IO interactions while maintaining an outward semblance of transparency. For example, many IOs redact sensitive portions of public-facing documents to conceal populist participation without withholding the broader findings entirely (Carnegie and Carson 2020). This allows them to share information without revealing the identity of contributing countries. The IAEA, for instance, produces reports on nuclear developments but refrains from disclosing the sources of its data.